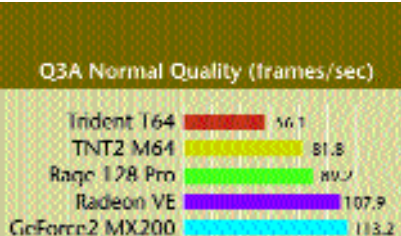


Normal quality: This is a very low-resolution, no-frills setting. It is not meant for the serious gamer, but rather for someone who enjoys that occasional game of *Quake* during coffee breaks. As you can expect, the mid and the high-end chipsets burn right through this test and are not worth talking about here. Only the absolute lower-end graphics chips like the Trident T64, nVidia TNT2 M64, ATi Rage 128 Pro, ATi Radeon VE and nVidia's GeForce2 MX200 are stressed under this mode.

The performance of the T64 was not up to par as promised by its specifications on paper. It managed only a lowly 56.1 fps. The nVidia TNT2 M64 scored 81.8 fps in the same test and easily overshadowed the T64. It comes across as a much safer bet if you want to have a decent gaming experience without burning a hole in your pocket. The final contender from amongst these old chipsets is the ATi Rage 128 Pro. It sports a 128-bit wide memory bus which provides it with a memory bandwidth of 2.5 Gbps, almost double that of the TNT2 M64. The core though, still runs at a lowly 140 MHz and is based on a 128-bit architecture. The per-



formance of the Rage 128 Pro falls between that of a TNT2 M64 and GeForce2 MX200 chipset and offers a healthy 89.2 fps. The ATi Radeon VE performs significantly better than its older cousin, breaking the 100 fps barrier with a score of 107.9 fps. If you fancy an ATi card which also offers excellent 2D and 3D quality visuals, then a card based on this chipset would be a good choice. The GeForce2 MX200 is the last budget chipset under consideration. It sports a similar architecture and is a direct contender with the Radeon VE chipset. The MX200 is also the fastest amongst the older generation chipsets (it delivers a cool 113.2 fps) which shouldn't be surprising considering the fact that it is a stripped down version of the higher-end GeForce2 chips.

High quality: This setting offers a balanced combination of a decent resolution with good picture quality and is quite harsh on the lower-end graphics chips. Since we have decided to keep the cut off at 60 fps, we'll have to wave our low-end buddies goodbye.

The mid-range of the graphics spectrum comprises of the GeForce2 MX400, ATi Radeon 7500, GeForce2 Ti VX and the GeForce4 MX420 chips. The GeForce3/4 and the Radeon 8500 are still too powerful to be perturbed at this setting.

The first of our two mini battles takes place between the GeForce2 MX400 and the Radeon 7500. The MX400 puts up a healthy score of 85.7 fps but it is not enough to distance itself from the 7500. We see that the ATi chip does pretty well for itself, registering a score of 115.3 fps. The Radeon 7500 is manufactured using a 0.15 micron process, which allows for an increased core frequency. This baby runs at a neat 270 MHz core and 460 MHz DDR memory speeds and has enough power to zoom past the MX400 without trouble. Moreover, the Radeon has some nifty memory optimisations which take it further past its competitor in this 32-bit colour test.

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